

SOCIAL SUPPORT & SERVICE

In the January 1, 2010, issue of The Guardian, Julia Neuberger a champion of volunteering in UK, wrote, “One change I’d like to see in the coming year is a move away from social networking sites. The rise of MySpace, Facebook, LinkedIn et al. has been an important cultural shift of the last decade, with many of us now using the web to make ‘friends’ and meet possible partners.”

There is nothing wrong with that in principle, provided they realize that the internet, however much it has transformed our lives for the better, **is no substitute for meeting people, getting out there and making friends.**

Those sites can only make initial connections; they cannot begin to develop the depth of real friendships, of real connectedness.”

Social support is a vital factor in the health of individuals and society. **Selfishness and pride** have separated nations, kingdoms, tribes, communities, and families. Selfish interests drive wedges between us (separation). True religion teaches that all nations are one in the eyes of God and that there is unity in the family of humankind. Regardless of our diversity, we are all one by creation, and we should respect the dignity of others in all societies. Such unity encourages a willingness to provide service to one another.



Support and willingness to support are vital to life

Why are support and willingness to provide service to others so vital to our daily living?

Various studies showed their importance on health :

1. As psychologist Abraham Maslow observed, **love is as essential to the growth of a human being as is food.**
2. According to psychologists Sheldon Cohen and S. Leonard Syme, social support has direct and indirect effects. Direct effects benefit both the giver and the recipient of social support and can be measured by comparing groups that receive and do not receive such support. Supporting one another helps us cope with stress. **It’s important to realize that we can be our own worst enemies by refusing the support of others.** Our attitudes may influence how we respond to the efforts of others to support us.
3. Psychologists L. F. Berkman and T. Glass stated that social support affects a person’s health through pathways such as mental outlook, health habits, and the way the body works:

- Our friends may have a positive or negative influence on us. **Supportive friends build self-esteem and self-efficacy.** Some friends subtly undermine and depreciate us.
 - Friends who themselves have unhealthful habits or even a lack of friends may lead us to seek comfort in unhealthful activities such as smoking, drinking, and overeating.
 - **Support from friends strengthens our coping abilities and reduces our stress. Criticism and negative attitudes affect our health possibly through the effect on the immune or cardiovascular system.**
4. According to E. Stice, J. Ragan, and P. Randall, **family support is the most important factor in the lives of adolescents.** Many have experienced the support of family and friends as a commitment on their part to love, nurture, and help them. Adolescents have high expectations of parents, and inadequate parental support increases the risk of adolescent depression. They become disappointed and confused when the anticipated help and positive reinforcement from parents are missing. The support of friends is also very important for adolescents.



5. The Commission on Children at Risk, a group of 33 children's doctors, research scientists, and mental health and youth service professionals, found considerable support for the role played by authoritative communities in health. These are communities that have a firm basis for belief in their sacred scriptures and from which they derive a value base. **For adults, religious faith and practice appear to have a sizable and consistent relationship with improved health and longevity, including less hypertension and depression, a lower risk of suicide, less criminal activity, and less use and abuse of drugs and alcohol.**
6. A study that is part of an eight-year investigative partnership between Vanderbilt University Medical Center and the Shanghai Institute of Preventive Medicine, beginning in 2002, was published in the Journal of Clinical Oncology. Meira Epplen et al. found that among 2,230 breast cancer survivors, women who scored highest on the social well-being quality-of-life scale had a 48-percent reduction in their risk of dying from cancer or having a cancer recurrence. Specifically, **women reporting the highest satisfaction with marriage and family had a 43-percent risk reduction**, and those with **favorable interpersonal relationships had a 35-percent risk reduction.** Social well-being in the first year after cancer diagnosis is **an important prognostic factor for breast cancer recurrence or death**, and some health professionals support the concept of designing breast cancer treatment to maintain or enhance social support soon after diagnosis is made in order to improve the outcome of the disease.



There is plenty of research to convince us that **surrounding ourselves with people who genuinely care about us can have a positive effect on our mental well-being.** A strong social support network can be critical in helping us through the stress of tough times, whether we've had a bad day at work or a year filled with loss or chronic illness. Supportive family, friends, and coworkers are a very important part of our lives.

Social support definitely benefits the receiver, but what about the giver? More than 150 years ago Ellen G. White wrote that **“doing good is a work that benefits both giver and receiver.”**

Benefits in providing social support to others :

Science today agrees.

1. Several studies by Drs. Siegel, Friedmann, Allen, and others, for example, printed in scientific journals, show that when a person provides love to their pets, they are healthier :

Back in the 1990s The American Journal of Cardiology published an interesting study conducted by Drs. Friedmann and Thomas known as the Cardiac Arrhythmia Suppression Trial (CAST). The doctors studied men and women who had sustained a heart attack and had irregular heartbeats. Here are surprising results from a sub-study:

- Only one of the 87 people (1.1 percent) who owned dogs died during the study.
- Nineteen of the 282 people (6.7 percent) who did not own dogs died.
- More than six times as many non-dog owners died compared to dog owners, which seems to indicate that **dog owners benefit from providing loving support to their pets.**
- Ironically, the drugs tested in the main study—encainide and flecainide—actually caused an increase in cardiac deaths and had to be stopped prematurely. ==➔ If these drugs had shown a six-fold decrease in deaths, you can be pretty sure that just about every doctor in the country would be prescribing them for patients with heart problems.

When was the last time your doctor prescribed “provide loving support to others or to pets”, in order to improve your health?

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Supporting even a pet, it is healthy Social support at work improves health

2. Elizabeth Brondolo, Ph.D., a psychology professor at St. John's University in Stony Brook, New York, and her colleagues conducted an interesting study that discovered clear and measurable effects on blood pressure when people care for one another in the workplace. The study was conducted with 70 agents in New York City who issue parking violations and traffic tickets.

This can be a stressful job as motorists often insult, threaten, or curse agents. During the study the agents wore a small monitor that recorded heart rate and blood pressure throughout the day. They also kept a journal of their workday whereabouts and activities.

At the day's end the agents completed a questionnaire that measured the emotional support they received from coworkers, immediate supervisors, and unit supervisors. **"The more people felt supported by their co-workers, the smaller the increases in their blood pressure** in the work environment." In fact, they had lower blood pressure during the most stressful times as well as throughout the workday.

This study definitely shows the **importance of having social support at work.**

Helpful support skills

Some of the most helpful support skills are very simple:

- Listen to colleagues carefully and attentively, respect the other person's privacy and dignity, choose words wisely,
- Be gentle and kind, keep a positive attitude,
- And avoid criticism.
- Treat the other person as you would want to be treated.

What is a social support network?

A social support network comprises friends, family, and peers. It **differs from other types of support groups in that it is not led by a mental health professional.** Although both types of support groups can play important roles in times of stress, a **social support network can be developed under conditions that are not stressful**, thereby providing the comfort of knowing that our friends are there for us if we need them. Rather than formal meetings with an official leader, a social support group can simply be friends eating lunch together, neighbors chatting

together, close relatives having a phone conversation, and even church fellowships. These all are ways to develop and foster lasting relationships with the people close to us.

Be the first to make a move

Let's not wait for someone else to make the first move. If you meet a person who you think might become a good friend, **invite** that individual to join you for lunch or other casual activities. These activities can include **volunteer groups** in causes of mutual interest, or even **exercising together** at a gym or with a walking group.

The importance of give and take

A successful relationship is a two-way street. **The better a friend we are, the better our friends will be.** Here are some suggestions for nurturing relationships:

- Stay in touch. Answering phone calls, returning e-mails, and reciprocating invitations let people know we care.
- Don't compete. Be happy instead of envious when friends succeed, and they will celebrate our accomplishments in return.
- Be a good listener. Find out what's important to your friends.
- **Don't overdo it.** In our zeal to extend our social network, be careful not to overwhelm friends and family with phone calls and e-mails.
- Appreciate friends and family. Take time to say thank you and to express how important they are to us. Be there for them when they need support.



In light of the benefits of social support, this statement makes much sense: “**Christian kindness and earnest consecration are constantly to be manifest in the life.**”(Medical Ministry p. 204)

Having a meaningful relationship with the Lord will produce loving relationships with others and a desire to give them genuine support. We will appreciate one another as children of God, regardless of our backgrounds. We will not have to worry about what to say or do,

because as we have a relationship with God, we truly will love one another, serve one another, strengthen and encourage one another, forgive one another, and pray for one another.

The social support **we give and receive** is very important to our overall health and well-being. Let us therefore live a life of praise to God by genuinely caring about the welfare of others and giving thanks for all things to Him who made us.

Self-evaluation questions

1. Human can improve their health by caring for others. A study to confirm this has been done on pets. What was the study about ? What were the findings?
2. Which helpful support skills do you know ?
3. A successful relationship is a two-way street. What does it mean ? By which ways can you nurture relationships with others?
4. What is a social support network? How is it different from formal meetings with a mental health profession?
5. What can be the role of our vertical relationship (with God) one the horizontal relationships (with fellow humans)
6. In which ways social support and willingness to support are vital to life according to the Psychologists L. F. Berkman and T. Glass ?